A day previously, he had scored another personal win on a sticky issue: a protest over moves to acquire 1,777 acres of farmland near Devanahalli, 40 km from Bengaluru, for an aerospace park. A 2022 notification, under the previous BJP regime, had triggered an agitation that didn't let up for three years. After the final notification this year, more activists rallied to the cause.

THE PRO-PEOPLE TRICK

Siddaramaiah's government first sought to negotiate a middle ground, offering to pare down the area to be acquired. Then the CM finally announced the acquisition would be dropped entirely, winning applause from agitators and freeing the Congress from a tricky lair.

The feelgood phase was capped on July 21, as the Supreme Court dismissed an appeal by the Enforcement Directorate on its money-laundering charges against the CM's wife, B.M. Parvathi. After its case sparked a raging controversy, she had returned the housing sites allotted to her by the Mysore Urban Development Authority in 2021, and then successfully challenged the ED summons in the Karnataka High Court.

Now, the SC has issued a strong caution to the agency against being 'used' for 'political battles'. Says the CM: "This verdict has exposed the malice behind the case and unequivocally cleared our names." Siddaramaiah called it a painful chapter—a useful metaphor for a whole phase he seems to have turned the page on. Well, at least for now. ■

Takeaways

- **Plagued by talk of a change of guard, Sidda fortifies his place with a flurry of wins**
- **SC bins ED plea to probe his wife in MUDA 'scam'**
- **Sidda also helms big OBC meet, wins over angry farmers**

▶ CHHATTISGARH

BREW HITS BAGHEL'S SON

The 'liquor scam' claims its biggest scalp yet, as the former CM cries political vendetta

By **Rahul Noronha**

IT'S THE GIANT-SLAYING phase, it seems, for the Enforcement Directorate (ED), after a long hunt for peripheral players. The latest arrest in what they're calling Chhattisgarh's own 'liquor scam': Chaitanya Baghel. The charges: acts linked to the sale of non-excise-paid liquor in 2019-22, when his father Bhupesh Baghel was CM. Besides causing a loss of Rs 2,200-odd crore to the exchequer, the ED alleges, Chaitanya's construction business netted in bribe money from liquor barons. In January, the ED had crested its previous peak in the case by arresting then excise minister Kawasi Lakhma, a Congress tribal MLA.

High drama erupted after the ED arrived for the arrest at Baghel's Raipur residence on July 18: the last day of the assembly's monsoon session and also Chaitanya's birthday. An angry Baghel tweeted

ARABINDA MAHAPATRA



THEY WANT JUSTICE Students in Fakir Mohan College in Balasore hold a candlelight vigil

By **Arkamoy Datta Majumdar**

ODISHA HAD BARELY recovered from the Balasore self-immolation case of July 12 when it had to confront yet another chilling incident that threw the deteriorating safety of women in the state in even sharper relief. On July 19, a 15-year-old girl was abducted and set ablaze in broad daylight by three unidentified men in the Balanga area of Puri district. She ran through a residential neighbourhood engulfed in flames, seeking help.

A primary witness, Dukhishyam Senapati, recounted that the girl ran towards his house—he and his family helped douse the fire and provided her with clothes.